



Training session

A Viet Cong woman demonstrates the use of an M1 carbine to a group of female recruits in September 1967. Only a few women in the Viet Cong were actual fighters—mainly in village defense forces where, like the male recruits, they were given some initial military training.

“For the **liberation** of our compatriots in the south, a situation of **boiling oil** and **burning fire** is necessary.”

VIET CONG SOLDIER DU LIC, IN HIS DIARY, DECEMBER 1961

» AFTER

As the Viet Cong grew in strength, the US steadily increased its support for the Diem regime.

MULTIFACETED THREAT

On January 12, 1962, helicopters flown by US Army pilots ferried 1,000 ARVN troops to **attack a Viet Cong** stronghold near Saigon in Operation Chopper. The Viet Cong continued to pose both a military and ideological threat throughout the war, causing the US to put the **Phoenix Program** into action in 1967.

HIDDEN NO MORE

US tacticians believed they could make it harder for the guerrillas to conceal themselves by clearing the jungle. Over the course of the war, vast tracts of Vietnamese countryside were sprayed with **Agent Orange**, a herbicide containing the deadly chemical dioxin.